

Kierkegaard on Original Sin:

Kierkegaard suggests that the readings of Genesis 3 that treat Original Sin as the cause of subsequent sin both commit a logical fallacy and miss the existential point of the story.

Augustine seems to be committing the following logical fallacy. The logical fallacy of interpreting original sin as the cause of sin is that it leads to a circular explanation of sin. The problem lies in the following predicament:

1. Original sin is the cause of sin
2. Sin as being caused by sin

These two theses, Kierkegaard suggests, cannot be admitted simultaneously, for the following contradiction arises:

1. If original sin is the cause of subsequent sin
2. And if Adam's sin is itself a sin
3. Then, either the original sin was present before Adam, and hence it was its cause
4. Or, there is no way of explaining what caused Adam's sin.
5. Given (2), Adam's sin should be explained as sin even if it came before any other sin
6. Given (5), we cannot appeal to original sin to explain Adam's sin
7. Thus, original sin as the cause of sin is untenable as an explanation
8. Therefore, original sin and sin must be given a common explanation

Kierkegaard essentially says that if Adam represents "a type of man" (Paul in Romans), then his sin is human. This implies that we need to explicate Adam's sin as any other sin.

"What is fantastical is that Adam enjoys the well-meant honour of being more than the whole race or the ambiguous honour of standing outside the race" (Kierkegaard).

Kierkegaard contends that the human race has a history that includes the history of sin. If Adam is part of the race (as it must be), then his sin is the same as **any** sin in terms of quality.

Thus, the mythological aspect of Genesis 3 is that reading Adam as incapable of sinning before the original sin yields a nonsensical interpretation. This is because the ‘causal story’ for the original sin cannot begin if Adam was incapable of sinning. Any that’s not a human is incapable of sinning BUT construing Adam as human means that he was capable of sinning **because** ...

Augustine got some parts of Genesis right. For example, his interpretation of humans as being related to Adam means that we relate to him not in terms of biology and hereditary sin, but instead as a type. That is, we are all agents who perform actions for which we are responsible, and hence feel guilty just in the same way as Adam did. Thus, from an existentialist perspective, some of Augustine’s interpretation is valid, in that he construes human nature as involving the notion of agency, responsibility, guilt, and anxiety. However, Augustine’s interpretation of Original Sin as the cause of sin conflicts with the above mentioned eight theses. Overall, the existentialist reading of Genesis 3, part of which is saved in Augustine’s interpretation, is found in the existential ideas of anxiety of choice, the regret of doing X over Y which manifests in the concept of Being-guilty and Being-responsible.

Kierkegaard’s existentialist interpretation:

Kierkegaard takes the Fall to mean two separate things. First, from a psychological standpoint, the story indicates the structure of human agency: namely, the prohibition placed on Adam by God presupposed his freedom, i.e., his being-able to do X over Y, **and the** possibility of temptation. The concept of ‘temptation’ may be understood as Adam possessing **desires** in general, from which point we can infer that human beings are taken in Genesis to have at least two faculties: a) the ability to perform actions and make choices, and b) have desires which have determined/able objects.

Regarding (a), Adam and Eve evidently have this ability since the prohibition to “not eat from the fruit of knowledge” would appear non-sensical in the case that either they were not able to eat from it (in which case the prohibition is void), or in the case that they had to eat from it (in which case the consequent punishment is inherently unjust). Thus, if the prohibition is to have meaning, then it should be interpreted as implying a prior ability to choose one’s course of action.

Regarding (b), the prohibition again would be non-sensical if the 'fruit of knowledge' is not interpreted as indicating the object of a concrete desire, which one can have **despite** prohibitions. In the same way that people sometimes desire what is not prudent, Adam and Eve desire what is prohibited. For example, the person who desires X while X is forbidden might acquire X despite being off bounds. Thus, according to Kierkegaard, the psychological interpretation of the Fall consists of an outline of human psychology that revolves around agency, and agency is taken to contain two distinguishable, albeit related, faculties: freedom of choice and desires.

The existential aspect of Genesis lies in extracting the story's significance regarding human existence. Kierkegaard suggests that psychology cannot explain the "qualitative leap" that happens when Adam and Eve become conscious of their transgression. For Kierkegaard, what may be described as 'the Fall' merely implies that Adam, in becoming conscious of his action and how his action relates to the prior prohibition, becomes conscious of the concept of Guilt. What changes after the Fall is the quality of Adam's subjective experience, in that his actions (both the original sin and subsequent actions) do not proceed from innocence but from anxiety and a standpoint of responsibility for consequences.

Thus, in realising the possibilities and implications of one's actions, Adam becomes conscious of a battery of interconnected concepts. Namely, every action is one possibility amongst others, one of which must be chosen; but every choice has future consequences that the individual cannot predict. This gives rise to potential regret which the individual can experience in advance of their decision, thereby inducing more anxiety. Moreover, every choice, even if a 'good' one, implies the non-actualisation of other possibilities, hence heightening the severity of the present anxiety. In addition, every action performed, and every intentional non-performance of some alternate action is the outcome of human agency for which one is responsible, thereby becoming conscious of Guilt or of bearing responsibility for one's choices. Therefore, from an existentialist standpoint, the meaning of Genesis is not primarily moral. Instead, it is a story about human nature that indicates the basic structures of humans as compared to animals. The difference is that we are conscious of and apply concepts such as guilt, anxiety, freedom, and possibility, all of which suggest that our comportment towards life is different from a mere sentient being.

The aforementioned psychological and existential interpretation of Genesis can be used against Dawkins' argument, which fundamentally dismisses the value of Genesis. Although it is true that if one reads the narrative in evolutionary biological terms, it lacks coherence (as Dawkins

rightly points out), the primary intent of the story **is not** to propose a scientific theory of species origin. Thinkers such as Kierkegaard, who identified as a Christian, openly acknowledge that reading the narrative in a literal or biological manner constitutes a mythological interpretation of the Bible. Nevertheless, when evaluating the significance of the story of the Fall, the criterion by which we assess its worth is not scientific. Kierkegaard determines this significance by pondering whether the story reveals something about us as human beings. If it does, what insights does it offer regarding human agency and responsibility?

Following Kierkegaard, we can salvage parts of Augustine's interpretation of the fall as an attempt to indicate aspects of human psychology and existential characteristics that demarcate the unique characteristics that make us the animal we are. The elements of guilt, sin, responsibility, and regret are inextricably linked with human nature, and this part of Augustine's reading can be considered convincing or sound.